Given this, a request to `/store/show/1` or `/store/show/1.html` will return HTML content, while `/store/show/1.xml` will return XML, and `/store/show/1.json` will return JSON. You can also pass the format in as an HTTP request parameter:

```
GET HTTP://pragprog.com/store/show/123?format=xml
```

Although the idea of having a single controller that responds with different content types seems appealing, the reality is tricky. In particular, it turns out that error handling can be tough. Although it's acceptable on error to redirect a user to a form, showing them a nice flash message, you have to adopt a different strategy when you serve XML. Consider your application architecture carefully before deciding to bundle all your processing into single controllers.

Rails makes it straightforward to develop an application that's based on resource-based routing. Many claim it greatly simplifies the coding of their applications. However, it isn't always appropriate. Don't feel compelled to use it if you can't find a way of making it work. And you can always mix and match. Some controllers can be resource based, and others can be based on actions. Some controllers can even be resource based with a few extra actions.